

A Thin Veiled Night
What Came Up the Riser

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EXT. THE ELLEN KAY / PIPE RACK - DUSK (SEPTEMBER 7, 1974)

Gloved hands crank a chain binder down on a stack of drill pipe. Rain is starting to come in flat.

REMY GUIDRY (19), skinny, new slicker still stiff, cranks the last notch.

Overhead, a BELL HELICOPTER comes in low toward the pad, tail skating sideways in the gusts. Spray tears off the gray swells sixty feet below the deck.

The PILOT looks at the wind through the bubble, shakes his head, and waves them off. The chopper peels away toward the coast and is gone into the gray.

Four men stand on the deck in slickers.

REMY (V.O.)

I was nineteen. First hitch. A jackup rig called the Ellen Kay, three steel legs in ninety feet of water, seventy miles south of Terrebonne Bay. Hurricane Carmen was coming.

REMY

He'll come back.

HOLLIS KANE (50s), the toolpusher, long and sun-cured, sour as a lemon rind, does not take his eyes off the weather.

HOLLIS

He won't. Not in this. We ride it.

DEWEY LANCLLOS (40s), the driller, spits over the rail and swears in Cajun French.

ELLIS WARE (58), the cook, big, gray-headed, white apron under his slicker, watches the sky with his hands in his apron pockets. Not a word. Turns and goes inside.

INT. ELLEN KAY / GALLEY - NIGHT

Pots bang. A fat Bible with a rubber band around it sits on the shelf by the coffee urn. Ellis cooks and sings, deep, slow.

ELLIS
(singing)
Will your anchor hold in the
storms of life, when the clouds
unfold their wings of strife...

Dewey and Remy hunch over coffee. Hollis eats standing up.

DEWEY
Tell him to sing a different song.

HOLLIS
You tell him.

Nobody tells him. Remy watches Ellis set an extra pork chop on his plate without a word.

REMY (V.O.)
My first week I made fun of his
singing behind his back. He heard
me through the wall. Next morning
he gave me an extra pork chop and
never said a word about it. I'd
been ashamed every breakfast since.

EXT. ELLEN KAY / LEGS AND HULL - NIGHT

Black waves the size of houses roll in out of the south and slam the steel legs with a boom like a train hitting a culvert. The whole hull shudders. Rain blows sideways. The derrick sways against the dark.

INT. GALLEY - CONTINUOUS

Coffee leans in the cups with the sway. A ladle walks across the counter on its own and drops.

REMY (V.O.)
We had a well under us. Eleven
thousand feet. Hollis had shut it
in before the evacuation. Under

the rig floor sat a stack of
valves two stories tall called the
blowout preventer. From the bottom
of it a steel pipe ran down
through the water into the mud.
The men called that pipe the riser.

INT. DOGHOUSE (DRILLER'S SHACK) / RIG FLOOR - MIDNIGHT

A cramped steel shack full of gauges. Dewey has his boots
up on the console. Hollis and Remy drink coffee by the
rain-blind window. The derrick creaks overhead.

Under the wind and the boom of waves, a sound.

KNOCK.

Dewey's boots come down off the console.

KNOCK. Two seconds. KNOCK.

DEWEY
That's the riser.

HOLLIS
Wave slap.

DEWEY
Waves don't count, Hollis.

KNOCK. KNOCK. Each one louder. Each one higher. Like a man
coming up a stairway.

Hollis takes the big six-cell flashlight off its hook and
goes out into the storm. Dewey follows. Remy looks at the
empty shack, then goes after Dewey.

EXT. RIG FLOOR / STAIRS - CONTINUOUS

Wind tries to throw Remy off the deck. He grabs the rail
and goes hand over hand behind Dewey to the stairs. Rain
pours through the steel grating above them as they climb
down.

INT. CELLAR DECK - CONTINUOUS

A low, dripping steel level under the rig floor. In the middle stands the BLOWOUT PREVENTER: a red iron tower of flanges, bolts, and hydraulic hoses. Under it, a round hole in the deck plate where the riser drops into black water.

Hollis aims the flashlight straight down along the pipe.

REMY (V.O.)
I've told this a hundred times
since. I've never once told it
right.

In the beam: A LIVING THING, thick as an oil drum, wound around the riser like a vine on a fence post. Coil on coil. Climbing.

Gray, wet skin plated with flat scales big as hubcaps that shine like old pewter. A ragged mane of seaweed and torn fishing net down its back. Each time it hauls up another coil, the scales KNOCK against the steel.

Then its head rises into the light. Long, narrow, like a horse's skull. No lips over the teeth. Eyes that throw the flashlight back flat and yellow like a deer's in headlights.

DEWEY
Mother of God.

Dewey sits down hard on the wet plate.

Hollis holds the light dead steady, breathing hard through his nose.

The thing wraps its front coils around the base of the blowout preventer and SQUEEZES.

Every bolt in the stack GROANS. A hydraulic hose rips loose and whips across the deck spraying red fluid. Hollis ducks. It cracks past over his head.

On the stack, a pressure gauge needle jumps and starts climbing.

REMY (V.O.)

Inside that stack were steel jaws called rams, closed tight on the well. If that thing squeezed them loose, eleven thousand feet of gas would come up and find a spark. And that would be the end of all four of us.

HOLLIS

Back up the stairs. Now.

INT. DOGHOUSE - CONTINUOUS

Hollis slams the levers on the preventer control panel. Lights flicker. The hydraulic pressure needle drops to ZERO.

DEWEY

That hose was the ram line. Hand wheels. Lock 'em by hand.

REMY (V.O.)

Every set of rams had a big iron hand wheel on each side, like an old truck's steering wheel. Sixty turns a wheel to screw them shut. Two wheels mattered. Down there. An arm's length from that thing.

Hollis looks at the climbing gauge. Looks at Dewey. Looks at Remy, the youngest, the skinniest, the only one who'll fit behind the bracing.

HOLLIS

Guidry. I'll hold the light. Dewey's on the choke. You turn the wheels.

Remy opens his mouth. No sound comes out.

ELLIS (O.S.)

I'm going with the boy.

Ellis stands in the doghouse door, slicker over his apron. The Bible is inside his slicker against his chest, rubber band off.

HOLLIS
You're the cook.

ELLIS
Yes sir. I'm going with the boy.

Ellis walks to the SQUAWK BOX on the wall, keys the talk button, and tapes it down with a strip of black electrical tape off Dewey's console. A speaker hiss carries out over the whole rig.

ELLIS (CONT'D)
(to Dewey)
Sing. The anchor song. You've
complained about it two years.
Sing it into that box and don't
you stop.

Dewey stares at him. Then Dewey Lanclos, who hasn't seen the inside of a church since his wedding, leans to the box and sings. Badly. Too fast.

DEWEY
(singing)
We have an anchor that keeps the
soul steadfast and sure while the
billows roll...

His voice booms out of every speaker on the Ellen Kay.

Ellis lays his big hand on the back of Remy's neck and steers him out into the storm.

INT. CELLAR DECK - CONTINUOUS

Knee-deep salt water sloshes across the plates. Every big wave comes up through the riser hole and the open sides and breaks white across the deck.

Remy and Ellis wade in. Hollis comes behind with the flashlight.

The thing has two more coils around the stack now. Its head sways on the far side at the height of Remy's chest. The yellow eyes swing toward the light.

From the speaker bolted to the bracing above them: Dewey, singing.

The head pulls BACK from the speaker, like a dog from a hot stove.

ELLIS

There. Go on, Remy. Turn.

Remy squeezes between the stack and the bracing. His hands find the first HAND WHEEL, cold and wet and as wide as his reach. He heaves. It fights him. Boot braced on the bracing, he heaves again. A quarter turn.

REMY

(counting out loud)

One. Two. Three...

A wave rolls up through the deck and buries him. He holds the wheel. Comes up spitting salt. Keeps turning.

REMY (CONT'D)

...eleven. Twelve.

Ellis stands in the open, in the beam, knee-deep, between Remy and the head. He pulls the Bible out of his slicker and holds it up shut in his left hand, the way a flagman holds a flag. He talks to the thing in the same voice he uses to call supper.

ELLIS

I know what you are. You came up out of the deep the way your kind always do. You don't scare me. I serve the One who walked on your water. He told the sea to be still, and it was still. In the name of Jesus Christ, you be still.

The thing STOPS. Head frozen at chest height. Coils locked. The bolts quit groaning.

Wind still screams. Waves still break. Dewey still sings. But on the riser, the thing holds as still as a photograph, yellow eyes fixed on Ellis.

Remy hits sixty-one turns. A deep CLUNK through the iron. Locked.

He drops to his belly in the water and crawls under the bracing to the second wheel, close enough to the thing's scales to touch them. He grimaces at the smell, bait-well rot. He grabs the wheel and turns.

REMY

One. Two...

Twenty-six turns in, A MONSTER WAVE.

It rises up through the deck with a roar and lifts all of them. It rips the flashlight out of Hollis's hand. BLACK. Salt water. Dewey's voice on the speaker.

The deck lights stutter back on.

Ellis is DOWN. The wave threw him across the plates against the base of the stack, right into the thing's coils. One loop closes over his legs. He hugs a flange, face barely out of the water. The Bible is gone.

The head comes down toward him.

ELLIS

(calm)

Turn the wheel, Remy. Turn the wheel.

Remy turns. His palms bleed where the iron rim has worn through. The gauge is still climbing. He keeps turning and he YELLS.

REMY

In the name of Jesus Christ, let
him go!

The loop on Ellis's legs slackens and drops away, quick as
a line thrown off a cleat. The head draws back.

The whole gray length of the thing UNWINDS off the stack
and pours back down past the riser into the dark Gulf, one
loop after another, scales rapping the pipe as it goes.
Fainter. Fainter. Gone.

Remy turns. Fifty-seven. Fifty-eight. Fifty-nine. CLUNK.

INT. DOGHOUSE - CONTINUOUS

The gauge needle stops. Falls. Dewey WHOOPS into the squawk
box, then starts the anchor song over from the top.

INT. CELLAR DECK / STAIRS - MOMENTS LATER

Hollis and Remy haul Ellis up the stairs between them,
Ellis's left leg dragging.

INT. DOGHOUSE - CONTINUOUS

They lower Ellis into Dewey's chair.

The wind STOPS.

All at once. No dying down. The rain quits with it. The
scream in the derrick goes silent. Under them the waves
keep rolling, big and slow, the slap on the legs softening
to a long easy wash.

Remy goes to the window. Over the top of the derrick:
STARS.

HOLLIS
Eye of the storm. That's the eye
coming over.

ELLIS
Could be.

REMY (V.O.)

The wind came back forty minutes later from the other side and blew till noon. No living thing came up the riser again.

INT. GALLEY - MORNING (MONDAY)

Gray daylight. Ellis has his bruised leg up on a chair, black from knee to ankle, coffee in hand. Remy sits on the bench, wrecked. Hollis, unslept, sits across from Ellis and turns his cup around on the table. Around. Around.

HOLLIS

Who were you talking to down there?

ELLIS

Same man the disciples asked about, the night He told the wind to hush. They said, who is this, that even the wind and the sea obey Him.

HOLLIS

And who is He?

Ellis drinks his coffee.

ELLIS

That's the question, Mr. Kane. Every man has to answer it for himself. I answered it a long time ago. The boy answered it last night.

(sets down his cup)

Your turn's coming.

Hollis looks at him a long moment. Gets up without a word and goes out on deck alone to wait for the helicopter.

INT. REMY'S HOUSE / HOUMA - NIGHT (PRESENT DAY)

REMY (71) at his kitchen table under a lamp. A yellowed newspaper clipping: a map of Hurricane Carmen's track, the

eye coming ashore near the Atchafalaya, south of Morgan City. A pencil X far to the east marks the Ellen Kay.

REMY (V.O.)

A week after, the Houma paper ran
Carmen's track. The eye came
ashore by the mouth of the
Atchafalaya around one in the
morning, sixty miles west of us.
We were never in the eye.

He lifts a keepsake off the mantel: a flat gray scale, big
as a hubcap, dull as pewter.

REMY (V.O.)

I found this jammed in the spokes
of the second wheel that Monday.
In 1980 I took it to a fish man at
LSU. He looked at it a long time
under his lamp and said gar, very
big gar, and handed it back
without looking me in the face.

INT. CHURCH / MORGAN CITY - DAY (1983, MEMORY)

A funeral. A YOUNGER REMY (28) at the front sings to a
small room, bad and too fast.

YOUNGER REMY

(singing)

We have an anchor that keeps the
soul...

REMY (V.O.)

Ellis passed in eighty-three. I
sang his song at the funeral, bad
and too fast, the way Dewey did.
Hollis Kane died in oh-two. I sat
in the back of the service in
Beaumont. Nobody there could tell
me what he answered.

INT. REMY'S HOUSE / HOUMA - NIGHT (PRESENT DAY)

Remy sets the scale back on the mantel. Outside, rain
starts to tick on the window.

REMY (V.O.)

Who is this, that even the wind
and the sea obey Him? I know what
I answered, down in the water with
my hands on that wheel.

He hums, then sings under his breath. Bad. Too fast.

REMY

Steadfast and sure while the
billows roll...

REMY (V.O.)

Our anchor held.

FADE OUT.